CHAPTER 84 Voting Behaviour

Meaning

Voting behaviour is also known as electoral behaviour. It is a form of political behaviour. It implies the behaviour of voters in the context of elections in a democratic political system.

Voting behaviour (or the study of voting behaviour) is defined in the following way:

Plano and Riggs: "Voting behaviour is a field of study concerned with the ways in which people tend to vote in public elections and the reasons why they vote as they do."

Gordon Marshall: "The study of voting behaviour invariably focuses on the determinants of why people vote as they do and how they arrive at the decisions they make".[1]

Oinam Kulabidhu: "Voting behaviour may be defined as the behaviour that explicitly reflects voter's choices, preferences, alternatives, ideologies, concerns, agreements, and programmes in respect of various issues, questions pertaining to the society and nation".[2]

SIGNIFICANCE

Psephology, a branch of political science, deals with the scientific study of voting behaviour. This is a new term popularised by the American political scientists and political sociologists.

The recorded history of voting goes back, at least, to the Greek Polis. The modern word for the study of voting behaviour, psephology, derives from the classical Greek 'Psephos', the piece of pottery on which certain votes, mainly about the banishment of those seen as dangerous to the state, were inscribed.[3]

The study of voting behaviour is significant for the following reasons:[4]

1. It helps in comprehending the process of political socialisation.
2. It helps in examining the internalisation of democracy as a value among the elite as well as masses.
3. It emphasises the real impact of revolutionary ballot box.
4. It enables to throw light as to how far the electoral politics continue or break with the past.
5. It helps to measure whether it is modern or primordial in the context of political development.

According to N.G.S. Kini, voting behaviour can be regarded as:

1. A mode of legitimising democratic rule;
2. Instancing "participation" in the political process involving integration into the political community;
3. Instancing an act of decision-making;